MOTB

By Robert Fulghum

ED: Most weddings are such comedies. *(long pause)* Not that they are intended as such. But since weddings are high state occasions involving amateurs under pressure, everything NEVER goes right.

(He takes one chair and places it DLC as a representations of MOTB. He never moves the chair again, and uses it to refer to her throughout the story.)

The central figure in this drama was the mother of the bride, the MOTB. Not the bride, groom, or minister. Mother. Usually a polite, reasonable, intelligent, and sane human being,

INTRODUCTION

Usually . . . . . [in the voice of a USED CAR SALESMAN} Congratulations! Your little girl is getting married. But being the mother of the bride (or MOTB) is not an easy role – not only is it a big job, but a job that has changed significantly over the years. Once upon a time mothers of the bride did most of the wedding planning, and thus got to have their own dreams realized. These days, your daughter will probably have her own vision – which may differ drastically with yours. But, hey . . . you don't have to let that stop you! You can be the MOTB of your dreams or maybe the one in MOTB by Richard Fulghum.

ED: [The] Mother [of this wedding] was mentally unhinged by the announcement of the daughter's betrothal. I don't mean she was unhappy, as is often the case. To the contrary. She was overcome with joy. And just about succeeded in overcoming everyone else in her joy.

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Nobody knew it, but this lady had been writing with a script for a production that would have met with Cecil B. DeMille's approval. A royal wedding fit for a princess bride. The father of the bride began to pray for an elopement.

She had seven months to work and no detail was left to chance or human error. *(He gets three other chairs and sets them up during the following, suggesting pews for the two sides of the church. One in front is for the MOTB, the other is for the mother of the groom. The other two chairs suggest pews a little further back in the church. There is a center aisle.)* Everything that could be engraved was engraved. There were teas and showers and dinners. And eight-piece brass-and-wind ensemble was engaged. The bride and groom met with the minister only three times----The MOTB was in his office more than the cleaning lady. Not only were the bridesmaid's outfits made to order, but the tuxedos for the groom and his men were *bought*, not rented, mind you. *Bought* *(he is finished setting up the church)* And, if all that wasn't enough, the engagement ring was returned to the jeweler for a larger stone—quietly subsidized by the MOTB. When I say the lady came unhinged, I mean UNHINGED. *(piano cue:roll)*

The judgment of fate rolled down the road, and the final hour came.

(Piano music: fanfare as Ed grabs the end of a white bridal runner, which as been preset D and unfurls it so that a church aisle is established from D to U. he places the U edge of the runner on the cut-off of the musical fanfare. Piano music underscores so much of the remainder of the story.)

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Guests in formal attire packed the church. Enough candles were lit to bring daylight back to the evening. In the choir loft of the orchestra gushed great music. And the mighty MOTB coasted down the aisle with the grandeur of and opera diva at a premier performance. *(After the line, he imitates the MOTB walking down the aisle, strutting, sneaking waves to her friends, etc., and finally taking her seat.)* Never has the mother of the bride take her seat with more satisfaction. She had done it. She glowed, beamed, smiled, and sighed.

(He rises to narrate the following as he paints a vivid picture. He helps us see all of the action and characters against the backdrop of his church set.) The music softened, and nine---count them nine----chiffon-draped bridesmaids lock stepped down the long aisle, while the groom with his men marched into place.

Finally, the wedding march thundered from the orchestra. Here comes the bride! Preceded by four enthusiastic min-princesses chucking flower petals, and two munchkin ring bearers-----one for each ring.

The congregation rose and turned in anticipation.
"Ah the bride."
She had been dressed for hours…if not days.
No adrenaline was left in her body.

(Putting the picture on hold, and stepping out of the world of the church, he takes the audience to the receptions hall and suggests the following) Left alone with her father in the reception hall of the church while the march of the maidens went on

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and on, she had walked along the table leaded with gourmet goodies and absentmindedly sampled first the little pink and yellow and green mints. Then she picked through the silver bowls of mixed nuts and ate the pecans. Followed by a cheeseball or two, some black olives, a handful of glazed almonds, a little sausage with a frilly toothpick stuck in it, a couple of shrimps blanketed in bacon, and a cracker piled with liver paté. To wash it down, a glass of pink champagne. Her father gave it to her. To calm her nerves.

(He returns to the moment in the church) What you notice as the bride stood in the doorway was not her dress, but her face, white. For what was coming down the aisle was a living grenade with the pin pulled out. *(pause)* the bride *(music stops)* …threw up. *(pause)* just as she walked by her mother *(pause)* and by "threw up" I don't mean a polite little ladylike burp into her handkerchief. *(pause)* "She puked. *(pause)* there's just no nice word for it. I mean she *hosed* the front row of the chancel *(pause)* hitting two bridesmaids, the groom, a ring bearer, and the minister. *(pause)* three camera's worth. *(pause)* The MOTB had thought of everything.

Having disgorged her hors d'oevres, champagne, and the last of her dignity, the bride went limp in her father's arms, while the groom sat on the floor where he had been standing, too stunned to function. And the mother of the bride moaned, slumped over and passed out cold. *(Indicates mother slumping over in rag-doll fashion.)*

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There was a fire drill then and there at the front of the church that only the Marx Brothers could have topped. *(With quick movements suggesting the frenzy to the keystone cops.)* Groomsmen rushed about heroically, mini-princess flower girls squalled, bridesmaids sobbed, and people with weak stomachs headed for the exit. *(The action stops as the music slows down suggesting the wafting smell.)* The smell…of fresh retch…drifted across the church.

Only two people were seen smiling. One was *(Indicating the front of the pew the chair for the mother of the groom.)* the mother of the groom *(pause)* and the other… was the father of the bride. *(Indicating him standing by his wife)*

What happened next? Well, we all went back to real life. Guests were invited to adjourn to the reception hall, though they did not eat or drink as much as they might have in different circumstances. The bride was consoled, cleaned up, and fitted out with a bridesmaid's dress, and hugged and kissed a lot by the groom. She'll always love him for that. When he said "for better or for worse" he meant it. THE CAST WAS REASSEMBLED WHERE WE LEFT OFF. A SINGLE FLUTE PLAYED A QUIET AIR, THE WORDS WERE SPOKEN AND THE DEED WAS DONE. Everybody cried, as people are supposed to do at weddings, mostly because the groom held the bride in his arms through the whole ceremony. And no groom ever kissed a bride more "tenderly" then him.

If one can hope for a wedding that it be memorable, then theirs was a raging success. NOBODY who was there will EVER forget it. *(He strikes the bridal runner)*

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They lived happily ever after as anyone does—happier then most, in fact. They have been married for 12 years now, and have 3 lovely children.

But that's not the end of the story. *(As he talks he arranges the chairs into a living room formation of imaginary TV sets, keeping the same designated chair for the MOTB in its original spot.)* On the tenth anniversary of this disastrous affair, a party was held. A feast was laid, best friends invited, and three TV sets were mustered. Remember there were 3 video cameras at the scene of the accident. All 3 tapes were shown at once. The effect. . . pretty interesting. Especially with the running commentary and the stop-action stuff that is a little gross when seen one frame at a time. The part that got cheers and toasts was when the camera focused on the grin of the father of the bride as he contemplates his wife being revived.

I really like this part of the story, not because of the party, but because of who organized it. *(Gesturing to her sitting in her chair)* of course. The infamous MOTB. The mother of the bride is still at it, but she's a lot looser these days. She not only forgave her husband and everyone else for their part in the debacle, she forgave herself. And nobody laughed harder at the videotapes then she.

There's a word for what she has. Grace.
And that's why the same grinning man has been married to her for forty years. And why her daughter loves her still.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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